Rightsworth

ORIGINAL RESEARCH · NOVEMBER 2026

The UK Sponsor Renewal Report 2026

Five seasons of front-of-shirt sponsors at 128 clubs across the Championship, League One, League Two, National League and Scottish Championship. Who stayed, who changed, and what was said when deals ended.

30%

of clubs had a different front-of-shirt sponsor the following season

105 of 350 season-to-season comparisons, 2021-22 to 2025-26

Rightsworth is a trading name of NextGenMediaGroup Ltd, company no. 12796511. Built from public data only; every source is listed on page 8.

SUMMARY

Six things the data says

What happened to the main sponsor at 128 UK clubs between 2021-22 and 2025-26.

70%

stay, every summer

Across 350 season-to-season comparisons, 245 clubs kept the same front-of-shirt sponsor and 105 changed. Roughly three in ten main sponsorships turn over each summer.

65%

kept in the Championship

Churn is highest near the top: 65% kept in the Championship, 67% in League One, 72% in League Two and 78% in the National League.

61%

kept after promotion or relegation

Clubs that changed division kept their sponsor 61% of the time, against 72% for clubs that stayed put.

46%

of new sponsors reach a third season

Of 85 new shirt sponsors, 57 (67%) came back for a second season. Of the 56 we could follow further, 26 were still there in their third.

2

seasons: the typical stated deal

Where a length was announced, deals ran one to five seasons, most often two. Long partnerships are built one short renewal at a time.

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exit stories mentioned outcomes

In the public stories we reviewed, sponsors and clubs cited strategy, costs, reputation, insolvency, ownership and geography. Only one talked about results, and nobody put a number on them.

Why it matters. For a lower-league club, the front-of-shirt deal is often the biggest single commercial contract. If three in ten change every summer, and new partners are the likeliest to leave, the first renewal is where clubs win or lose most sponsor income.

SECTION 1

Who keeps their sponsor

Share of clubs with the same front-of-shirt sponsor the following season.

By league (league at the start of the pair)



The higher the league, the more often the shirt changes. We haven't tested why. Championship shirts carry more national brands, including betting firms (7 of the 24 Championship front-of-shirt sponsors in 2025-26), and bigger fees mean more competition for the slot. Lower down, more sponsors are local businesses.

By summer



Summer 2025 was the steadiest in the data: 80% of clubs kept their sponsor. It may not last. In 2026, Burton Albion and Hartlepool United both appointed an agency to find new headline partners (Bdaily, May and June 2026).

SECTION 2

When sponsors are most likely to change

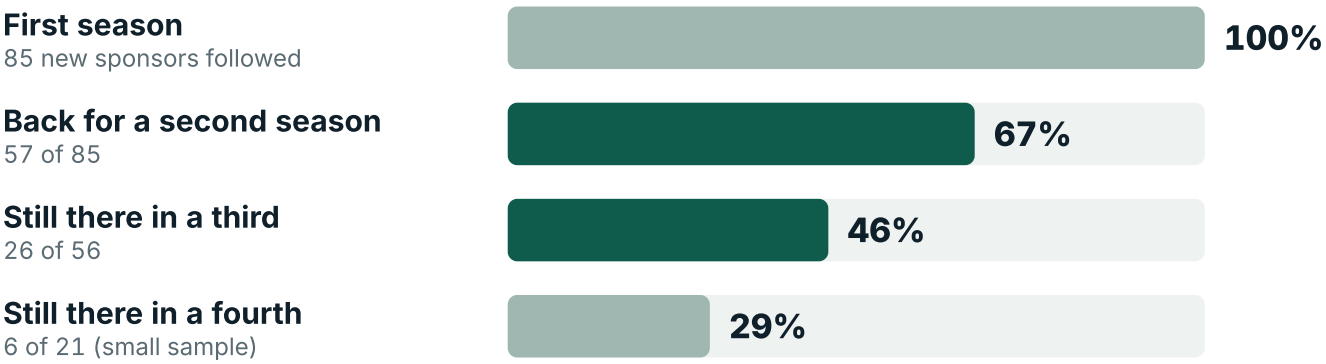
Two moments stand out: a change of division, and the first renewal.

Promotion and relegation



A new division changes the price, the audience and sometimes the sponsor's interest. Promotion can raise the price; relegation can shrink the audience. Either way the renewal tends to be reopened.

How long new sponsors last



A "new sponsor" is one that replaced a different sponsor on the shirt. A third of new partners didn't make a second season, and fewer than half reached a third. Of those that renewed once, about three in four renewed again.

> **Read with care.** A change on the shirt isn't always a sponsor walking away. It can be a better-paying replacement, a charity slot, or a sponsor moving to another asset at the club. The data measures change, not the reason.

SECTION 3

The long-stayers, and how long deals run

15 of the 104 front-of-shirt sponsors in 2025-26 had been on the same club's shirt for all five seasons we tracked.

On the shirt all five seasons, 2021-22 to 2025-26

CLUB	SPONSOR
Accrington Stanley	Wham
Bradford City	JCT600
Cardiff City	Visit Malaysia
Cheltenham Town	Mira Showers
Forest Green Rovers	Ecotricity
Mansfield Town	One Call Insurance
Milton Keynes Dons	Suzuki
Northampton Town	University of Northampton
Peterborough United	Mick George Group
Portsmouth	University of Portsmouth
Reading	Select Car Leasing
Rochdale	Crown Oil
Stoke City	bet365
Tranmere Rovers	Essar
West Bromwich Albion	Ideal Heating

Five seasons is the floor, not the full story: several of these go back much further.

Deal lengths stated in public

CLUB	SPONSOR	LENGTH	YEAR
Woking	Nuffield Health	1-year extension	2026
Burton Albion	Prestec	2 seasons	2018
Cheltenham Town	Mira Showers	2-year extension (sponsor since 2008)	2020
Raith Rovers	Dean Park Hotel	2 seasons	2022
Bradford City	JCT600	3-year extension (association of about 40 years)	2022
Chesterfield	GF Tomlinson	3 years	2016
Rochdale	Crown Oil	5 years	2016

Only seven announcements we found gave a length, so this is a small sample. The pattern is clear, though: one to three seasons is normal, and five is rare. Even a 40-year partnership like Bradford City and JCT600 is renewed every few years.

> **So what?** A long partnership is a run of short renewals. Each one is a fresh decision, often by someone new at the sponsor.

SECTION 4

Why sponsors leave: what was said in public

Eight public stories from UK football, rugby league and motorsport, quoted as published.

Gillingham and MEMS Power Generation

CLUB STRATEGY

League Two · 2023

After 12 years as main sponsor, MEMS's deal ended when the club changed its commercial model. Head of commercial Joe Comper: “In recent history, we've relied heavily on one business occupying the majority of our sponsorship inventory.” MEMS chairman Colin Jarvis spoke of “great sadness and disappointment”. MEMS sponsored Notts County, then returned to the front of Gillingham's shirts in June 2025.

Source: KentOnline, 7 Apr and 19 Jun 2023; Gillingham FC, 9 Jun 2025

Chesterfield and GF Tomlinson

OUTCOMES NOT MET

National League · c. 2019

The construction firm signed what was billed as the club's most lucrative shirt deal in 2016, then didn't take up its option to renew. It said the reciprocal business it hoped for never came: “We haven't been able to come to any reciprocal agreements.” A club director said the concerns hadn't been raised with him.

Source: Derbyshire Times

Preston North End and PAR Group

FAN FEELING

Championship · 2021

The club moved from betting sponsors to a local manufacturer. Adviser Peter Ridsdale: “We were mindful that some of the supporters had issues with us being sponsored by betting companies.” He said the new deal was better financially. PAR Group stayed on the shirt for four seasons.

Source: Chorley Guardian

Raith Rovers and Val McDermid

REPUTATION

Scottish Championship · 2022

The author ended her shirt sponsorship after the club's signing of David Goodwillie drew strong criticism. The away-shirt sponsor also withdrew. The Dean Park Hotel took the home shirt on a two-season deal.

Source: The Courier, 2022

Bristol City and Huboo

SPONSOR INSOLVENCY

Championship · Feb 2025

The club ended the deal midway through 2024-25 after the sponsor went into administration and failed to meet the terms of the deal. Fever became front-of-shirt partner for 2025-26.

Source: Bristol24/7, Feb 2025

Stocksbridge Park Steels and Eco Power

GEOGRAPHY

Non-league

The sponsor didn't extend into a third year, saying it wanted to “focus our commercial support more locally”. Eco-Power Group has been Doncaster Rovers' front-of-shirt sponsor since 2022-23.

Source: The Star

Rugby League and Betfred

COST PRESSURE

Super League · Sep 2026

Betfred is ending nearly ten years as title sponsor after the 2026 season. Founder Fred Done pointed to wage inflation and tax rises: “you have to look at all your costs.”

Source: Gambling.com, 21 Sep 2026

Power Maxed Racing and Pendragon

CHANGE OF OWNER

BTCC · Feb 2025

After Pendragon was bought, its title deal with the team ended two years early. The team called it “unexpected and late”.

Source: Autosport, 13 Feb 2025

The pattern: deals rarely end over a measured result. They end in a cost review, a strategy change, a takeover or a bad headline, when nobody has evidence of what the deal delivered. Only Chesterfield's sponsor talked about outcomes, and it put no number on them.

SECTION 5

What clubs can do with this

Practical steps for commercial teams, drawn from the patterns above.

1. **Treat the first renewal as the danger zone.** A third of new sponsors don't make a second season. Agree in writing at kick-off what the sponsor wants from the deal, in their words: leads, sales, staff hiring, introductions.
2. **Start the renewal six months out, not six weeks.** Deals run one to three seasons. Put each sponsor's renewal date in the diary the day the contract is signed.
3. **Plan for promotion and relegation.** Changing division cuts retention from 72% to 61%. Write a division clause into the contract, with the price and the package for each outcome.
4. **Bring evidence, not just exposure.** Exits come in cost reviews and takeovers, when someone new asks what the deal sold. Promo codes, tagged enquiries and introductions logged through the season are what survive that question.
5. **Hear the concern before the press does.** At Chesterfield, the sponsor's frustration reached the club through the newspaper. A mid-season review meeting costs an hour.
6. **Know your exposure.** If your sponsor is in a sector under cost pressure, such as betting, plan a replacement shortlist a season early.

Rightsworth Sponsor Outcome Report

An evidence-graded report for one sponsor: leads, sales and customers, an ROI range, and a priced renewal package. Delivered in ten working days, from £1,150 excl. VAT for founding partners.

Free 15-minute Renewal Risk Check

raymond@rightsworth.com · rightsworth.com

A simple renewal calendar

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Contract signed	Write down the sponsor's objectives in their words. Set up codes, tagged links and an introductions log.
Mid-season	One-hour review with the decision-maker: what's working, what isn't, what they need to see at renewal.
9 months out	Renewal risk check: objectives, evidence, relationship, sponsor's own situation.
6 months out	Gather the evidence: leads, codes, sales, introductions, delivery against contract.
3 months out	Put the outcome report and the next-season package in front of the sponsor.
Renewal meeting	Agree the next deal, including what happens on promotion or relegation.

For brands: the same evidence works the other way. If you sponsor a club, a Sponsor Value Audit tells you what the deal sold before you decide to renew.

APPENDIX

Method, caveats and sources

How we built it

We recorded the home front-of-shirt sponsor for every club in five leagues and each season, 496 club-seasons in all. Each club was followed across divisions. For every club present in two consecutive seasons, we noted whether the sponsor was the same or changed: 357 pairs, of which 350 could be compared. We left out 7 pairs where there was no single named sponsor (rotating charity or local-business slots, or no sponsor) or where sources disagreed.

Company names were standardised where one firm appears under two spellings. Smurfit Kappa and Smurfit Westrock are treated as one sponsor, as the company was renamed after its 2024 merger.

Checks

We checked about 36 club-seasons against independent sources. Three differed: Bristol City 2024-25 (we use Huboo, the sponsor at the start of the season), Hartlepool United 2024-25 (corrected to Workwear Express) and Hartlepool United 2025-26 (excluded). One pair moves the headline rate by about 0.3 points.

Caveats

- A change isn't a failure. The data measures change, not why.
- Front-of-shirt only. Sleeve, stadium and other deals aren't counted.
- Five seasons cuts off longer histories.
- Rugby, cricket, basketball and motorsport appear in the stories, not the numbers: we found no consistent public season tables for them.
- Public statements are partial. We quote, we don't guess motives. We didn't contact any club or sponsor.

Sources

Season data. Wikipedia season articles, "Personnel and kits" tables: EFL Championship, League One and League Two 2021-22 to 2025-26; National League and Scottish Championship 2022-23 to 2025-26. Accessed 14 Nov 2026. One URL per row in the dataset.

Spot-check. Club and sponsor announcements, local press and Football Kit Archive sponsor histories for 14 clubs.

Exit stories. KentOnline (7 Apr and 19 Jun 2023); Gillingham FC (9 Jun 2025); Derbyshire Times; Chorley Guardian; The Courier (2022); Bristol24/7 (Feb 2025); The Star; Gambling.com (21 Sep 2026); Autosport (13 Feb 2025); Bdaily (5 May and 3 Jun 2026).

Deal lengths. Woking News & Mail (18 Jun 2026); Prestec (23 Jul 2018); Bdaily (10 Aug 2020, 25 Jul 2022); The Courier (2022); Derbyshire Times; Rochdale Online (5 Aug 2016).

Full links and the dataset (CSV) are published with the web version at **rightsworth.com/uk-sponsor-renewal-report-2026/**.

Corrections

If you spot an error about your club or company, email raymond@rightsworth.com and we'll correct it.

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